

THE DAY IN BETWEEN

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

INTRO: The phrase “*In Between*” automatically triggers a thought process that let’s the hearer know that something is unsettled about the situation, or a transition is going on. As individuals, we often grapple with a plethora of transitions throughout life.

We have all known the agony of being in between with: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Relationships...
- Health issues...
- Financial decisions...
- Educational processes...
- Employment concerns...

Being in between suggests that change is in the air and when this is the case, we are always hopeful the modifications will prove to be beneficial to our future. The greatest transition

in the history of the world occurred on the first Easter and the modifications proved to be beneficial to our future and eternity.

Easter is without a doubt the greatest day in the history of the world. 1 Corinthians 15:17 (NKJV) *“And if Christ is not risen, your faith is futile; you are still in your sins!”*

Today I want to take a little different look at the events surrounding the Easter story. The three contiguous days of the first Easter were of epic proportions, they: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Changed the paradigm of religion...
- Changed the course of human history...
- Changed the delivery of the Gospel message...
- Changed the eternal destiny of billions of souls...

Most Easter sermons deal with the final day of the story, but I want to focus on all three day's beginning with the events in the Garden of Gethsemane.

DAY ONE:

(PLAY CLIPS OF THE PASSION OF THE CHRIST AS THE FOLLOWING BULLET POINTS ARE MADE)

- Jesus had supper with His disciples...
This meal occurred in the Upper Room in Southwest Jerusalem and it was here He revealed that one of His own would betray Him.
- He faced a sleepless night in the Garden...
He prayed while His closest friends slept.
- He agonized before the Father in prayer until His sweat became as great drops of blood... He prayed three times, ***“If it be possible let this cup pass from me.”*** But finally He prayed, ***“Not my will but thine be done.”***
- He was betrayed by Judas and then deserted by all the disciples...
- He was arrested in the Garden...
- He was brought back to the palace of the High Priest... It was here that He was interrogated by Annas a former High Priest and Caiaphas, Annas' son-in-law.

- He was tried by the Sanhedrin, and found guilty of blasphemy...
- He was sentenced to die for a crime He never committed...
- He was sent to Pontius Pilate at the Antonia Fortress...
- Pilate did not find fault with Him...
- Pilate sent Jesus to Herod who did not want to get involved...
- Herod sent Jesus back to Pilate...
- Pilate caved in to the pressure of the crowd and ordered Jesus to be tortured and crucified...
- Jesus was beaten with thirty-nine stripes...
- Jesus was required to carry His cross from Pilates Judgment Hall to Golgotha... It is believed the cross of Jesus weighed one hundred twenty-five pounds and He carried it for two and one half miles!

Jesus was placed in the position of either calling for relief from his temporal circumstances which would have short circuited the redemption process, or setting an example of

faith for road weary pilgrims to follow when the spiritual night is so dark one cannot see the next step to take.

If Jesus had caved under the pressure: **(PLAC
ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The enemy would have defeated the Fathers answer for sin...
- The redemption process would have been back to square one...
- Mankind would have continued in sin without a Savior to call on...
- Evil would have continued to dominate Gods crowing creation, mankind...
- The world would probably have self destructed in a cesspool of sinful behavior...

The good news is that nothing of the sort transpired!

The will of the father was for Jesus to subdue the flesh and finish the redemption process.

We must NEVER forget; Jesus was crucified as the sinless son of man rather than the sinless Son of God.

Jesus cried from the cross, ***Eli, Eli lama-sa-bach-tha-ni. Which being interpreted is My God, My God, why has thou forsaken Me?"***

We know the Father did not forsake Jesus and we know God is not going to forsake us, but it sure feels that way from time to time!

DAY TWO – THE DAY IN BETWEEN:

Day two is a day that is often overlooked in this story. Day two is a period of time that accomplished immeasurable results. **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The disciples of Jesus forsake Him...
- Joseph of Arimathea buries the body of Jesus in his own tomb...
- The tomb is sealed to insure His interment would be final... (The governmental leaders were concerned that someone would steal His body and claim that He had risen... They were listening more closely than the Disciples... The soldiers

were told “*Make it as secure as you can.*”)

- As soon as the tomb was sealed Jesus laid aside His humanity and dawned His divinity... (The soldiers would have felt quite foolish if they had known they were guarding an empty tomb)
- Jesus paid a visit to the halls of Hell... (He conquered the keys of death and hell)
- He preached to the captives in paradise... (Those who died under law who were anticipating a coming Messiah)

DAY 3:

Matthew 28:1-6 (NKJV) “*Now after the Sabbath, as the first day of the week began to dawn, Mary Magdalene and the other Mary came to see the tomb. ²And behold, there was a great earthquake; for an angel of the Lord descended from heaven, and came and rolled back the stone from the door, and sat on it. ³His countenance was like lightning, and his clothing as white as snow. ⁴And the guards shook for fear of him, and became like dead men. ⁵But the angel answered and said to the*

women, “Do not be afraid, for I know that you seek Jesus who was crucified. ⁶“He is not here; for He is risen, as He said. Come, see the place where the Lord lay.”

Day three begins in a cemetery, at sunrise, on the first Easter morning. A cemetery is not a place where you find a lot of hope, quite the contrary is true: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- A cemetery is a burial ground for the dead...
- A cemetery is a place where dreams are laid to rest...
- A cemetery is a place where hope dims, flickers and dies...
- A cemetery is a place for reflecting on what could have been...
- A cemetery is a place for beautiful flowers to wither and die...
- A cemetery is a place where grief deadens the tune of victorious songs...
- A cemetery is a place where money loses its power to buy its way out...

- A cemetery is a place where we are forced to accept the finality of fate...

In this particular cemetery there were no doubt old tombs that were well marked by the weathering streaks, of Father Time. Others were recently occupied.

On the third day, two women could be seen making their way into the cemetery through the gray dawn shadows of a spring day. The women who were coming to this cemetery were obviously emotionally distraught and with painstaking effort, they made their way to the tomb of Jesus.

Tenderly and gently, as only a mother can, one of these ladies had come to give her son a decent and proper burial. A mother and her trusted friend were paying their last respects to a son whose life held such promise. But now, at only thirty-three and one half years of age, the beloved son who had given so much would be nothing but a faint memory, and a short inscription on a tomb marker!

There is no pain that can equal the pain of a mother who has lost her child.

Matthew draws our attention to another group of people in the cemetery, and they were a group of soldiers, who were frightened out of their minds. (Guy who fell into an open grave late one night not knowing a drunk had fallen in there earlier in the evening...)

Remember, these guys were calloused, emotionally unattached monsters, but they were frozen by fear when a man from outer space showed up with the keys to a sepulcher housing a political and religious martyr!

This cemetery on the outskirts of Jerusalem appeared to be the most unlikely place on the earth to experience a miracle. But the greatest miracle in human history was about to transpire before the unsuspecting eyes of the soldiers and the women!

It shouldn't surprise me, but it does: God performs some of His most incredible activities in some of the most inconspicuous places!

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)

- God chose the backside of the desert to defy the law of conflagration by allowing a bush to burn but not be consumed...
- God chose a group of shepherds and a Judean hillside to display heavens choir of angels...
- God chose a stable in Bethlehem to be the birthplace of His only Son...
- God chose a hillside in Israel to contradict the law of diminishing returns by feeding 5,000 men with a little boy's lunch...

Based on what we already know, it should not come as a great surprise to us that God stages the miracle of all miracles in a cemetery!

This miracle was not performed in space, a science lab, a palace, or before an important crowd! This miracle was performed in a cemetery!

God chose this cemetery, which represents man's extremity, to display the awesome power of his Divinity!

There is another incident that occurred in this cemetery which must not be overlooked, Matthew says ***“Behold, there was a great earthquake.”***

This incident represents a natural phenomenon. An earthquake is normally referred to as an *“Act of God”* by the modern liberal media. In other words, an earthquake is something that is beyond our control. The capacity of an earthquake for destruction is almost without limits. An earthquake:

- Bends steel...
- Busts boulders...
- Buries buildings...
- Breaks structures into splinters, effortlessly...
- Bounces mountains around like a rubber ball...

- Breaks holes in the surface of the earth like tearing a piece of paper...

This natural phenomenon is a circumstance of major proportion. Two such quakes had been observed in the previous seventy-two hours, one when Jesus died, the earth shook like a bowl of jelly to express its horror, and now it shakes again to celebrate the resurrection of the Rock of Ages!

Just minutes before the resurrection the circumstances could not have been worse; Jesus was not sick or comatose, He was dead! Jesus was not only dead He had been buried and in the grave three days!

The circumstances could not have been worse! God chose the very worst circumstances to let us know that nothing that happens to us is too difficult for Him to handle!

God takes the darkest night of despair and turns it into a miracle for us! Psalms 30:5 (NKJV)

“For His anger is but for a moment, His favor

*is for life; Weeping may endure for a night,
But joy comes in the morning.*”

Matthew 28:2-4 (NKJV) “*Behold, there was a great earthquake; for an angel of the Lord descended from heaven, and came and rolled back the stone from the door, and sat on it.*”

³His countenance was like lightning, and his clothing as white as snow. ⁴And the guards shook for fear of him, and became like dead men.”

Let me tell you, there were more than two emotionally distraught women and a couple of frightened soldiers present when Jesus was resurrected! The Scripture say’s “*The angel of the Lord came down!*” *Everywhere one looks there are angels in this story: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)*

- Angels celebrated His advent...
- Angels sympathized with Him in His agony...
- Angels comforted bereaved believers at His ascension...

- Angels are schedule to share the triumph with Him in the apocalypse that is soon to come...

The events of the third day called for something beyond human resources, so it should be no wonder that angels broadcast the news, when His abolition was aborted.

Napoleon once said, *“Extraordinary problems call for extraordinary remedies.”*

The Resurrection of Jesus meets that criterion. It proceeded beyond the ordinary! This was an extraordinary remedy, prescribed by an extraordinary God, who thinks nothing of going beyond finite limitations!

Because of the events of the third day, the tomb that Jesus occupied is now empty, no longer needed, and can be returned to its owner! Jesus did not buy a tomb, He just borrowed one; He was only going to use it for three day's! The Lord of Glory moved out via the Resurrection!

CONCLUSION:

The resurrection is the greatest miracle in the history of the world, and tells me that **there's nothing that God can't do!** **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME UNTIL ALL ARE ON THE SCREEN, THEN LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERVICE)**

- God has never seen a problem He could not solve...
- God has never seen a hurt He could not heal...
- God has never seen a battle He could not win...
- God has never seen a question He could not answer...
- God has never seen an obligation He could not meet...
- God has never seen a failure He could not fix...
- God has never seen a loss He could not restore...

The reason that God can do all of this for us is because of the events of the three days surrounding Easter, and now the tomb is empty!

He's alive! Because He lives, you and I can live
as well!